blame us?" A few days later there is this entry in the diary: "We had an N.S.P.G. meeting again on our negotiating posture in the upcoming meeting with Gromyko and the arms talks. I believe the Soviets have agreed to the talks only to head off our research on a strategic defense against nuclear weapons. I stand firm we cannot retreat on that, no matter what they offer." A few days after that, on December 18, I made this entry in my diary: "A meeting with the Joint Chiefs re our military force compared to that of the Soviets. In strategic weapons, when the Soviets refer to maintaining stability they mean superiority and they have it. More and more I'm thinking the Soviets are preparing to walk out on the talks if we won't give up research on the strategic defense system. I hope I'm wrong. . . ."

Just before Christmas, Margaret Thatcher came to Washington and Nancy and I invited her to Camp David. I met her helicopter in a golf cart and took her to Aspen, our weekend home, before going on to the main conference building, Laurel. She had just had a meeting with an up-and-coming member of the Soviet Politburo named Mikhail Gorbachev who, she said, expressed strong Soviet reservations over the SDI. When she seemed to share some of his misgivings I wondered if the British were concerned about the SDI and my hope of eliminating nuclear weapons because of fears that without the American nuclear shield the Soviets' superiority in conventional weapons would pose a threat to Western Europe. I assured Margaret we were simply embarking on a long-term research effort, not making a commitment to deploy the SDI; obviously, I said, it would be some time before we knew it would work as we hoped.

During this period in late 1984, we had another problem in the arms control arena to deal with: Until that time, both the Soviet Union and the United States had agreed to abide voluntarily by the expired SALT I treaty limiting nuclear